Old Trafford to watch the first team play? *Watch the man playing in your position. One day, you're going to take his place.* When Andrei left Old Trafford, I couldn't help wondering, could I?

When we joined up for pre-season training, most of the younger players were waiting to see who the boss would sign to replace the big names who'd left. A couple of months later, with us all in the side, we were still assuming he'd have to bring in new players. How could he stick with just us young boys? Manchester United are a massive club, and you can understand that the fans expect success straight away. At the back of our minds, though, there was the hope that we'd get the chance to prove ourselves. Nowadays young players are different: they're more confident in themselves. In the situation we were in, you'd expect someone to say it straight out: 'Are we going to get a game here, or what?' Myself, the Neville brothers, Nicky Butt and Paul Scholes weren't like that. None of us asked and the boss didn't tell us. He just went ahead and started the new season with the youngest United side anybody could remember since the Busby Babes.

First game of the season, away to Aston Villa, we got hammered. I was on the bench and by the time I got on in the second half we were already 3–0 down. I scored: Denis Irwin chipped the ball forward for me. I got a good first touch on my instep, let the ball run forwards a little and then shot from the edge of the box. A slight deflection took it past Mark Bosnich, who was in goal for them. I remember celebrating almost on my own. We were still a couple of goals down, of course, and John O'Kane, who'd also come on as a sub, was about the only player who came over and hugged me.

For the remainder of the game I ran around all over the place trying to make a difference. I was quite pleased with myself afterwards. But the manager wasn't. I was devastated. He had harsh words for me in the dressing room, telling me how important it was for the team that I stay in my position. After that defeat at Villa Park, the media were ready to write off United's season. The manager seemed to be putting his faith in a group of youngsters and the pundits weren't having any of it. They were all saying the same thing. Unluckily for him, Alan Hansen was the one who said it on *Match of the Day*:

'You'll win nothing with kids.'

I was sitting in front of the television that night. I'm sure the other lads were, too. Coming back from Birmingham there might have been doubts in some minds. As a group, we had risen to any challenge put in front of us. But on the coach that evening I think there were a few of us wondering if this was